

The Explosive Child: Collaborative Problem Solving (CPS) Script

Plan B Conversation Guide for Inflexible & Frustrated Children | Framework: Dr. Ross Greene's Lagging Skills & Collaborative Solutions Model

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Clinical Resource Packet

CHILD'S NAME	AGE / GRADE	DATE	COMPLETED BY

The 3 Steps of a Collaborative Problem Solving (CPS) Plan B Discussion

CPS STEP	PARENT SCRIPT (EXACT WORDS TO USE)	CLINICAL GOAL & CHILD RESPONSE
Step 1: Empathy (Gather Information)	"I've noticed that it's been really hard to start homework at 5:00 PM lately. What's up?" <i>If child says "I don't know":</i> "That's okay. Take your time. Is it the maths or feeling tired after school?"	Do not judge, correct, or solve. Gather the child's perspective completely. Clarify their underlying concern without defending your rules.
Step 2: Define Adult Concern	"Thanks for telling me. My concern is that when homework is delayed until 8:00 PM, you get super exhausted, bedtime is late, and you feel rushed in the morning."	State the adult concern clearly: safety, learning, health, or impact on family members. Do not repeat lectures.
Step 3: Invitation (Mutual Brainstorming)	"I wonder if there is a way for you to get a good break after school so your brain rests, but also make sure maths is finished before dinner? What ideas do you have?"	The solution must be mutually satisfactory (addresses both child's concern and parent's concern) and realistic (can actually be done).

Timing is Everything: Never attempt a Plan B conversation during or immediately after a meltdown. Conduct Plan B when both parent and child are completely calm, fed, and regulated.